

The Old Dog

The old dog lumbered into the kitchen. Her nails clicked against the metal floor. There was a time when the sound would have irritated her, but the world had gone quieter since then, and so did she. Metal boxes, screens, tubes, and gears marked the boundaries of the kitchen. The old dog knew this.

The sun was rising as the old dog walked towards her corner, shifting one aching limb at a time. A tube hung overhead, directly above her metal bowl. When she reached her bowl, she waited. The wait was longer than it used to be, but that was fine. Somewhere nearby, a scanner recognized her presence, and the tube began to rumble. The old dog folded her hind legs beneath her. After a moment, food rained from the tube, landing in the metal bowl. It would have been loud, but the bowl was designed to absorb noise, so it was not. When the tube finished, the old dog made a noise as she stood. She was satisfied with the bowl, so she ate.

Once the old dog had licked the bowl clean, she took a step back. A hatch opened beneath the bowl, and it fell. The old dog felt the familiar warm glow coming from the hatch. She knew not to get close, but sat so the heat could warm her bones. When the hatch shut, the bowl would be gone. Melted, formed, and polished back into its original state, then delivered to the old dog's corner as if nothing had happened. The old dog did not know this, nor did she care. When the heat was gone, the old dog began her journey to the yard.

The house was old. Its pipes wheezed, its gears ached, and its scanners stuttered. There was a time when everything was shiny, but the house had forgotten. There was a time when its humans had come and gone. It remembered their faces, but not their names. A boy with messy brown hair and an impish smile. A girl with long blonde hair rolling her eyes. A woman beaming at them. An old man taking their photo. The house knew when this had happened, but it did not know why. It did not know where the humans had gone. The house continued, waiting for them to return. The kitchen would be clean, the parlor would be warm, and the beds would be made.

When the old dog arrived at the door, the sun was overhead. After a moment, a scanner found her and unlocked the door. The house grunted as it shifted the block of metal. The old dog waited. When the door was open, the old dog stood once more and walked outside.

The daytime was brighter than usual. The house knew it was springtime, but had no one to tell. The sky was light gray with ashy clouds. The old dog took care to descend the porch steps. They creaked, making a hollow, tinny sound, before the old dog reached the dry lawn. She meandered through the grass, marked by what was left of the blackened fences. This was the old dog's lawn. She could see plenty more dry grass in front of other broken homes, but she knew this one. She knew where to sit when the sun poked through the clouds, she knew which patches would die first during the winter, and she knew the way the shadows fell at the end of the day. And so, this one was hers. Eventually, the old dog found a suitable location, lowered her hind legs, and urinated into the grass.

Once the old dog was finished, she wandered back to the steps, and waited to be let back inside. Once again, she sat patiently. Eventually, the door whirred, opening back up for her, and the old dog lumbered towards the parlor.

The house went to work. A vicious poison spread through pipes under the yard. The grass withered quickly, and the soil turned pale. Spinning machines dug up the lawn, a mess of tubes vacuuming up the remains. Mechanical limbs spread a thick layer of fresh soil over the surface, and a rolling machine injected a slimy concoction into the ground. Within a few hours, the grass would return. The old dog did not know this, nor did she care.

When the old dog arrived in the parlor, she barked once. It was not angry, she could not do that anymore. It was polite and quick, like asking a question. The house responded by lighting the fireplace. A warm glow radiated from the screen, and the old dog wandered towards it. She folded her hind legs and laid down. The house piped in warmer air, while circuits under the tile began to whir. To the old dog, it was the same glow as the hatch. To the house, it was something completely different. She lay there, resting, as the sun fell.

The old dog missed her humans. Like the house, she did not know where they had gone. She remembered them, and a part of her knew they were not coming back. She remembered the boy with the impish smile and the girl who pretended to be annoyed by him. She remembered playing with them as a puppy, before retiring to the parlor to sleep. She remembered the mother, who always cared for her. Who gave her a real bowl to eat from and a bed to sleep in. And she remembered the old man. His calm, comforting presence, enjoying a life well lived.

As the sun disappeared, and the sky turned dark, the old dog fell asleep for her last time. An hour or two later, the house noticed, and opened a hatch beneath her, emanating the same bright glow. The house worked. Machinery buzzed, unmaking, sanitizing, remaking. In the morning, the old dog would return. The same. Changed.

The house did not know this, nor did it care.